

Schilmoeller & Schoenfield, PC — Staff Portal & AI Communications Agent

User Guide & Integrations

Audience: Jane, firm staff, and whoever administers the portal. **Date:** 2026-06-04

This guide covers day-to-day use of the portal and how to set up its integrations. For migration/hosting/operations, see `docs/HANDOFF.md` ; for the technical deep-dive, see the repository `README.md` .

The best companion to this guide is inside the app. The **Tutorials** page (sidebar → Tutorials) walks every major feature with live visual examples, and Settings → **Integrations** contains step-by-step setup guides with status indicators. This document deliberately contains no screenshots — the portal handles real client email, and screenshots of production data don't belong in a shareable file. The in-app tutorials use safe dummy data instead.

Part 1 — Using the App

1.1 Getting started

- **Access:** the portal is a website — open the firm's portal URL in any browser and bookmark it. On a phone, use the same URL in the mobile browser (no app store install). *Note: the mobile layout works but is not yet optimized — a refinement is on the roadmap.*
- **Login:** email + password (an admin creates accounts under Settings). Sessions last 8 hours, then you log in again.
- **First visit:** head to the **Tutorials** page first — it's a guided tour of everything below, with interactive examples.
- **Password:** change it anytime under Settings → your profile section.

1.2 What the system does while you sleep

Every 60 seconds the portal checks the firm's mailbox. Each new email is:

1. **Categorized** by AI (document request, appointment, status update, complaint, ...) with a confidence score
2. **Tiered:** T1 (routine, auto-eligible) / T2 (staff review — the default) / T3 (escalate to Jane)
3. **Drafted:** a suggested reply is written from the firm's knowledge base, past approved replies, and rejection feedback
4. **Escalated** if it matches the firm's escalation criteria (IRS notices, complaints, legal issues, ...) — these go straight to Jane's queue

Nothing is ever sent automatically. Auto-send is held behind two independent switches (an environment flag and an admin setting), and both are OFF in production. Every email a client receives was approved by a person first.

1.3 The Inbox (Emails page)

- **Statuses:** New → Categorized → Draft Ready → Sent / Resolved; plus Deleted and Spam (see below).
- **Filters & search:** filter by status, category, tier, assignment, or saved folder; full-text search covers subjects, summaries, senders, and message bodies.
- **Bulk actions:** select multiple threads to resolve, assign, delete, spam, recategorize, or save in one go.
- **Spam / Delete mirror to Outlook.** Deleting or spamming a thread in the portal also moves the real message to Deleted Items / Junk Email in the mailbox — and it can be recovered from Outlook if needed.
- **Keyboard shortcuts:** `j / k` walk the list, `Enter` opens, `a / r` approve/reject the active draft. Press `?` for the full list.
- **Outlook stays in sync.** Replying from Outlook (e.g. on your phone) is fine — the portal sees the conversation either way.

1.4 Reviewing and sending AI drafts

Open a thread → the right-hand panel holds the AI draft:

- **Read the AI's reasoning:** category, confidence meter, and a "what shaped this draft" indicator (past approvals, saved messages, rejection feedback for this category).
- **Edit** the draft text directly — your version is kept alongside the AI original.
- **Tone override:** regenerate in a different tone (professional / empathetic / urgent / direct).
- **Attachments:** attach files at any point while drafting (paperclip). Attachments survive regeneration, and you can also download any attachment a client sent — or one the firm sent — from the conversation bubbles.
- **Approve → Send.** Sending starts a 10-second countdown with an Undo button (you can disable the countdown per-user under Settings → Sending).
- **Your signature is added automatically at send** — you'll see exactly what will be appended in the dashed "Signature" preview under the editor. It's your personal signature (Settings → My Signature), or the company signature if you haven't set one.
- **Reject (with a reason)** when a draft misses the mark — the reason feeds back into future drafts for that category. Regenerate does a reject + fresh draft in one step.

1.5 Composing a new email

Click **Compose** (sidebar) for a Gmail-style compose window:

- Write it yourself, or switch to **"Draft with AI"** and describe what the email should say — the AI proposes a subject and body you can edit.

- To / Cc, attachments, and the same automatic signature handling as replies. Sent composes create a new conversation thread in the portal.

1.6 Saved folders

- When you send a reply, the conversation **auto-files into a folder named after the client** — "I dealt with it" filing without any clicks.
- You can also save threads or individual messages manually, with optional notes, into any folder. The **Saved** page lists folders with counts and supports cross-folder search.

1.7 Escalations (Jane's queue)

Emails flagged T3 land on the **Escalations** page, sorted by severity (low → critical). Workflow: **Acknowledge** (claimed) → **Resolve** (with notes). The dashboard and sidebar surface unattended high/critical items.

1.8 Knowledge Base — teaching the AI

The AI drafts from the **Knowledge** page's entries:

- **Response templates** — full example replies
- **Policies** — firm rules the AI must respect
- **Snippets** — reusable phrases

Categorize and tag entries; the draft generator pulls matching context per email category. *Keeping this current improves drafts more than anything else.* The AI also learns passively from your approvals, edits, saved messages, and rejection reasons.

1.9 Analytics — monitoring the system

The **Analytics** page (sidebar) shows, over a 7/30/90-day range:

- **AI Token Usage** — today's usage against the daily budget (the bar goes amber at 70%, red at 90%), daily history, and how many days the budget ran out. When the budget is exhausted, drafting pauses until midnight UTC and categorization falls back to keyword rules — the page tells you if that's been happening.
- **Email Volume** — conversations per day, category mix, triage tiers
- **Draft Workflow** — how many drafts were generated/sent, the **edit rate** (how often staff change AI drafts — falling = the AI is learning), and rejections
- **Escalations** — open items and daily trend

1.10 Settings

Section	Who	What
My Signature	everyone	Your personal signature, appended to everything you send. Leave blank to use the company signature.

Section	Who	What
Company signature	admin	The firm-level block — used for auto-sent mail and as everyone's fallback.
Sending	everyone	Disable/enable the 10-second send countdown (per-user, per-browser).
Team Members	admin	Create/deactivate accounts, set staff vs admin role.
Triage Rules	admin	Per-category T1 eligibility + confidence thresholds. Complaint/urgent/promotional are locked to review-only.
Integrations	admin	Live health of database, AI provider, email provider, notifications — plus the setup guides below.
RunPod	admin	Self-hosted GPU controls (dormant — the firm runs on Anthropic).

1.11 Outlook sync — what mirrors, and what doesn't

The portal works directly on the live Microsoft 365 mailbox, but the two sides are **not** fully two-way. Knowing the direction of each action avoids surprises when you also work in Outlook.

App → Outlook (these actions DO mirror to Outlook):

In the portal	In Outlook
Delete a conversation	Its incoming messages move to Deleted Items
Spam a conversation	Messages move to Junk Email (and train the junk filter)
Send a reply or a new email	The sent message appears in Sent Items

Outlook → App (currently one-directional):

- **New incoming mail is picked up.** The poller checks the inbox about every minute and pulls in unread messages automatically.
- **Deletions, moves, and read-state changes made in Outlook are NOT reflected back in the portal.** The poller only *adds* new inbox mail — it does not reconcile messages you delete or move on the Outlook side. If you delete an email in Outlook, it can still appear in the portal (and vice-versa is covered — deleting in the portal *does* reach Outlook).

Practical guidance: for anything you want mirrored, act **in the portal** (its delete/spam/send all reach Outlook). Treat Outlook-side cleanup as portal-invisible for now. (Saved folders are currently in-app organization only; mirroring folders to real Outlook folders is a planned enhancement.)

Part 2 — Integrations Setup (admin)

Everything below is configured with **environment variables** on the hosting platform (see `.env.example` in the repository for the full annotated list). The portal's Settings → **Integrations** page

shows live status for each and contains the same guides interactively.

2.1 Email — Microsoft 365 via Graph (production setup)

Uses an Azure app registration; no mailbox password involved.

1. Sign in to **portal.azure.com** with a Microsoft 365 **admin** account → "App registrations" → **New registration**. Single tenant; redirect URI blank.
2. In the app: **API permissions** → Add → Microsoft Graph → **Application permissions** → add `Mail.Read`, `Mail.Send`, `Mail.ReadWrite` → click **Grant admin consent** (required — without it the portal can't read mail).
3. **Certificates & secrets** → New client secret (≤24 months). Copy the value immediately — it's shown once. Note the **Application (client) ID** and **Directory (tenant) ID** from Overview.
4. Set the environment variables and redeploy: `EMAIL_PROVIDER=msgraph MSGRAPH_TENANT_ID=<directory-tenant-id> MSGRAPH_CLIENT_ID=<application-client-id> MSGRAPH_CLIENT_SECRET=<the-secret-value> MSGRAPH_MAILBOX=jane@yourfirm.com`
5. Within a minute or two the Integrations page should show **Healthy** and new mail starts appearing.

Secret expiry: client secrets expire (max 24 months) — calendar a reminder; when it lapses, polling and sending stop until a new secret is set.

2.2 Email — IMAP/SMTP (alternative)

Works with Gmail, free Outlook, etc., using an app password. Set `EMAIL_PROVIDER=imap` plus the `IMAP_*` / `SMTP_*` variables (IMAP and SMTP usernames **must match** — the portal refuses to boot otherwise, to protect email deliverability).

Caveat: spam/delete mirroring to the mailbox works on Microsoft Graph only — on IMAP, portal-side Delete/Spam does not move the real message.

2.3 AI — Anthropic (production setup)

```
LLM_PROVIDER=anthropic
ANTHROPIC_API_KEY=sk-ant-...      # console.anthropic.com → API Keys
DAILY_TOKEN_BUDGET=1000000        # daily cap; 0 disables
```

The budget caps spend per calendar day (UTC). The Analytics page tracks it. An OpenAI-compatible self-hosted path also exists (`LLM_PROVIDER=openai_compat` + a RunPod pod with auto start/stop orchestration) but is dormant — see `.env.example` if it's ever revived.

2.4 Notifications — Slack and/or log file

Escalations and auto-send events can notify:

- `SLACK_WEBHOOK_URL` — create an Incoming Webhook in Slack pointed at an alerts channel and paste the URL
- `NOTIFY_LOG_FILE` — a file path for JSON-line notifications

Either, both, or neither — at least one is recommended so urgent items aren't missed.

2.5 Verifying everything at once

Settings → **Integrations** shows four cards — Database, AI provider, Email provider, Notifications — each with live status and configuration summary. All green = the system is fully operational. The public health endpoint (`<backend-url>/health`) is suitable for external uptime monitors.

FAQ

Does using Outlook directly break anything? No — the portal polls the same mailbox and threads conversations by their mail headers. Reply from wherever is convenient.

Why did a draft pause / categorization look "keyword-based" today? The daily AI token budget likely ran out — check Analytics. It resets at midnight UTC.

Who sees what? Staff and admins see the same inbox, drafts, saved folders, knowledge base, and analytics. Admin-only: user management, triage rules, company signature, integrations, audit log, and the compliance export.

Where's the audit trail? Every state-changing action (sends, approvals, deletes, setting changes) is recorded — admins can browse it on the Audit Log page or export thread data via the compliance endpoint.

Something looks wrong — where do I start? Settings → Integrations (anything not green?), then Analytics (budget exhausted?), then the Audit Log for what happened recently.